

Fantasy for Vagrant Flute

Timothy W. McDunn

Concept

aeternitas igitur est interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio.

“Eternity, therefore, is the full and complete possession of life unending in a single moment.”

—Boethius, *Consolatio Philosophiae*

Many of my works are more like sculptures than pieces of music. I build them kind of like an architect, with emphasis on symmetrical structures, which have little relation to time. In the past, however, I’ve composed a prescribed path for performers and listeners to follow through the geometric designs in each piece. In this work, my relationship to space and time has changed. The path taken through the design is not controlled by me — just as, in plastic arts, the vagrant eye of a viewer is not constrained by the dictates of a sculptor.

The piece is dedicated to my beautiful wife, the source of my inspiration and all my passion.

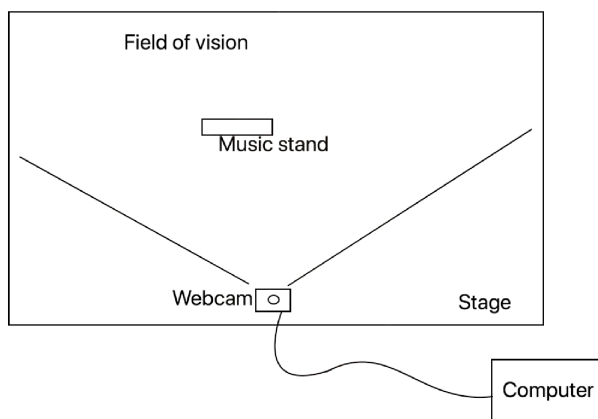
Instructions

The Five-limit inter-Face

The piece entails an electronics setup that generates pitches in five-limit just intonation. In this tuning system, pitches can be represented on a two-dimensional grid, in which every step upward stands for an ascending pure perfect fifth and every step to the right a pure major third. The pitch content of the piece derives from a series of fractals (self-similar geometric figures) constructed in this space.

The performer interacts with this sound sculpture through an interface that tracks his or her position on stage. The interface captures a live webcam feed of the performer and applies facial recognition algorithms to determine the performer’s location. The location is then mapped to the corresponding point on the two-dimensional grid, activating the sounds.

Setup



- Stereo Sound
- Additional live electronics triggered off-stage at computer
- Music stand center stage
- Wireless clip on mic attached to flute, routed to computer
- No other faces (besides performer’s) in field of vision

Interpreting the Score

In passages labeled *kairatic time*, there is no metronomic pulse. Each system of music in these passages should last approximately 30 seconds. Indications to move across the stage are approximate; ultimately the performer should activate the interface however feels most musical in the moment. Generally, I suggest slow dramatic movements with an air of gravitas; even passages marked ‘quick’ are relatively slow, while those marked ‘slow’ are even slower. The flute player should improvise with air and key clicks wherever the score indicates movement. A second person should operate the computer off-stage, pressing the corresponding number on the keyboard that matches the rehearsal marks given in the score to activate electronics cues.

When hairpin symbols appear above the staff or in empty space, they indicate changes in speed. The performer should begin moving more quickly or slowly across the stage. The score only indicates speed of movement. Direction and position are left to the discretion of the performer.

Changes in Speed

	Gradually move more quickly
	Gradually move more slowly

Speed Indications

<i>q</i>	Quick
<i>mq</i>	Medium Quick
<i>ms</i>	Medium Slow
<i>s</i>	Slow
<i>i</i>	Immobile

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kairatic time *enter once sounds nearly die*

Flute *(walking, improvise air and key clicks)*

ppp *i* *s* *s* *s* *i*

Fl. *pp* *i* *s* *mq* *q* *s*

Fl. *p* *s* *q* *q* *q* *s*

Fl. **1** *mf* *s* *q* *q* *q* *i*

Fl. *p* *i* *q* *q* *q* *q* *s*

Fl. *mf* *s* *q* *i*

2 *mf* *ff* *mf* *mf* *ff* *mf* *freely explore landscape and improvise on these two cells plus air and key clicks*

3 ♩. = 180 ca.
played at stand

Fl. *f*

Fl. *ff* *mf* *f*

Fl. *ff*

Fl. *leaving stand, explore freely* 30" ca.

Fl. *played at stand* *f*

Fl. *ff* *mf* *f*

Fl.

Detailed description: The page contains seven staves of music for Flute 1. The first staff begins with a tempo marking '3 ♩. = 180 ca.' and the instruction 'played at stand'. It features a series of eighth and sixteenth notes with various dynamic markings. The second staff continues with more complex rhythmic patterns and dynamics like *ff*, *mf*, and *f*. The third staff shows a transition to a new section with a *ff* marking. The fourth staff includes a long, sustained note with the instruction 'leaving stand, explore freely' and a duration of '30" ca.'. The fifth staff returns to a 'played at stand' instruction with a *f* dynamic. The sixth and seventh staves continue with intricate melodic lines and dynamic variations.

Fl. *leaving stand, explore freely* 3
15" ca.

Fl. *played at stand*
f *ff* *p* *ff*

Fl. *f* *ff* *p* *ff*

Fl. *fff*

Fl.

Fl. *leaving stand, explore freely*
30" ca.

Fl. *kairatic time*
i *4*
i $\triangleleft q \triangleright$ $\triangleleft q \triangleright$ $\triangleleft q \triangleright$ *i*

Fl. *pp*
i $\triangleleft s \triangleright$ $\triangleleft mq \triangleright$ $\triangleleft q \triangleright$ *s*

Fl. *ppp*
i $\triangleleft s \triangleright$ $\triangleleft s \triangleright$ $\triangleleft s \triangleright$ *i*